

Now, if these two are the only ways you used the Start Menu, you don't really need a start menu at all to be honest. You can still pin applications to the taskbar. And if you want to search for apps, you can still press the start button and simply start typing on the start screen, the process is the same.

If you really want a menu though, there are a few options for you. The lightest, cheapest and most straightforward option is to use the toolbars function of the taskbar to create a simple start menu toolbar. Here is how you can do that:

- ▶ Right click on the task bar, and under the Toolbars menu click on "New toolbar..." a dialog will open up for picking a folder.
- ▶ The contents of the Start Menu are actually stored in two folders, the folder for applications installed for the current user is located at: `%APPDATA%\Microsoft\Windows\Start Menu\Programs` Paste this in the file open dialog, press enter, and select it as the location for the toolbar.

You will notice a new toolbar called Programs on your taskbar, and you can click the arrows next to it to access the list of installed programs on your computer.

There is another important folder here:

`%PROGRAMDATA%\Microsoft\Windows\Start Menu\Programs`

This lists applications that have been installed globally.

Of course this is very far from a perfect solution so, don't worry, there are a few apps that can get back the start menu.

Start Menu Replacement Apps

There were hacks earlier that restored the start menu in Windows 8, unfortunately in the release version of Windows 8, the start menu has been entirely removed. There is nothing to restore. Don't worry though, there is a growing list of applications for replacing the Start Menu. These applications recreate the start menu functionality from scratch.

Here are three of the best:

Classic Shell: Considering the range of features offered and the price, this is probably the best software that you can get.

It's been around for a long time and aims to bring back features or UI designs that were present in older versions of Windows but were removed in newer versions. In Windows 7 it can bring back the old classic style of start menu that was there in Windows 9x. In Windows 8 it gives you an option of what kind of start menu you want, including a Metro-themed start menu.